

THE BALLAD OF THE SCEPTRE OF FINAL WINTER

Come close, my ash-clad brothers, Come near, you frost-bitten few;
The fire is low, the road is lost, And the night is looking through.
I sing of a ward in a shuttered hall, Where the dead leaves claw the
stone— The Sceptre of Final Winter, And the silence it calls its
own.

No crown was set upon its brow, No oath was carved in gold; Yet men
grew still beside its shape, And women's blood ran cold. Its visual
identity is that of a ward Bearing the name that all tongues fear:
The Sceptre of Final Winter, Though no warm name may linger near.

It was forged in 87 AS, So the old black tablets say. I have not
seen the hands that wrought it; I have not lived that day. But the
iron remembers, or so we swear, And the stone remembers too— The
Sceptre of Final Winter, With a hush in all it knew.

"Who shall dare to take it up?" The starving sentry cried. "Who
shall pay the hidden price And stand with frost inside?" The answer
passed from mouth to mouth, A tithe no priest could mend: Attunement
to it costs 55, And none can name the end.

Some call it mercy, some call it doom, Some call it merely a ward. I
call it the last shut door At the edge of the world. For it radiates
an atmosphere Of cold finality; Not rage, nor grief, nor triumph—
Only what must cease to be.

I saw it once—perhaps I dreamed; The moon was a broken bowl. Its
shadow lay across the floor Like winter over a soul. No blade was
drawn, no bell was struck, No herald gave command; Still every
breath became a prayer, And dust forgot the hand.

O Sceptre of Final Winter, Ward of the closing sky, Keep your
counsel in the frozen dark, Let the fevered kingdoms die. If you are
doom, then doom is clean; If mercy, mercy's thin. The cold is
waiting past the door, And the cold will let none in.

So sing no praise at the Sceptre's name, Nor curse it in the rain. A
ward may bear what hearts cannot, And silence outlast pain. Remember
87 AS, remember 55, Remember the final hue— The Sceptre of Final
Winter, And the winter waiting through.